



second-longest title drought, trailing only the nine-year gap experienced between 1984-85 and 1993-94.

However, on March 14, the prolonged wait came to an end as Ajinkya Rahane lifted the Ranji Trophy for the first time as captain, achieving a mission he embarked on three months prior. While Rahane assumed leadership only at the onset of the Vijay Hazare Trophy, the domestic 50-over tournament, head coach Omkar Salvi had been mapping out the roadmap since his appointment in June of the previous year.

Throughout the three knockout matches, Mumbai found itself in precarious situations at various junctures, yet it was rescued by different individuals, showcasing the true character and essence of the Lion's crest that adorns a Mumbai cricketer's whites with pride. Here are several key factors that played a pivotal role in guiding Mumbai back to its glory days.

B for bowlers, C for Championship

The cricketing adage holds true for the Mumbai team's performance in the 2023-24 season: "Batters win games, and bowlers win championships." Throughout the league stage, it was the bowling unit, spearheaded by the unassuming Mohit Avasthi, that not only secured Mumbai's qualification for the knockouts but also propelled it to the top of the league standings.

Out of a possible 140 wickets in the league stage, Mumbai claimed an impressive 128, laying the groundwork for its triumph in five out of seven matches. This stellar performance compensated for Mumbai's relatively shaky batting lineup, both on paper and on the field, in recent times.

Although Mumbai registered only four centuries during the league stage, the bowlers' consistency and dominance enabled the team to accumulate bonus points at ease,

Ending long wait: Mumbai's victory in the 2023-24 season marked its first title in eight years, with its previous win dating back to 2015-16. EMMANUEL YOGINI



BRIEF SCORES

Mumbai 224 (Shardul Thakur 75, Yash Thakur 3-54, Dubey 3-62) and 418 (Musheer 136, Iyer 95, Dubey 5-144) **beat Vidarbha** 105 (Rathod 27, Kotian 3-7, Kulkarni 3-15) and 368 (Wadkar 102, Nair 74, Kotian 4-95, Musheer 2-48) by 169 runs